

Governance Checklist

A practical governance checklist to help organisations assess whether their job evaluation process is clear, disciplined, and sustainable.

Introduction

A job evaluation methodology can be technically sound and still lose credibility if the governance around it is weak. In many organisations, grading problems emerge not because the framework itself is wrong, but because decision rights are unclear, requests are raised inconsistently, approvals are not disciplined, documentation is incomplete, appeals are handled unevenly, and the process is not maintained over time.

Good governance helps ensure that job evaluation remains fair, transparent, explainable, consistent, and sustainable. This checklist is designed to help organisations assess whether the governance around their job evaluation process is strong enough to support confidence in outcomes over time.

1 Approval and Decision Rights

A clear governance process starts with knowing who is responsible for what. Check whether:

- ☐ there is clarity on who may request a new job evaluation or re-evaluation
- ☐ the authority to approve evaluation requests is clearly defined
- ☐ the roles of HR, line management, committees, and executive approvers are understood
- ☐ there is a distinction between evaluating a role and approving a grade outcome
- ☐ final approval rights are documented for new roles and regraded roles

GOOD GOVERNANCE SIGNS

- ✓ request rights are controlled
- ✓ approval levels are documented
- ✓ escalation points are clear
- ✓ no one part of the organisation can bypass the agreed process

2 Policy Clarity

Governance is much stronger when the organisation has a clearly stated policy. Check whether the organisation's job evaluation policy clearly defines:

- ☐ the purpose of job evaluation

- ☐ the scope of the policy
- ☐ when evaluation or re-evaluation may be triggered
- ☐ what information is required before grading can take place
- ☐ what should be excluded from job evaluation
- ☐ the appeals process
- ☐ the key governance roles involved in decision-making

GOOD GOVERNANCE SIGNS

- ✓ managers know when a request is legitimate
- ✓ people understand what should not influence grading
- ✓ the process is stable enough to support consistency over time

3 Committee Discipline

A committee structure can strengthen consistency, but only if it is well governed. Check whether:

- ☐ the committee has a clearly defined purpose
- ☐ membership is appropriate and representative
- ☐ quorum requirements are defined
- ☐ members understand their responsibilities
- ☐ meetings are properly prepared and documented
- ☐ conflicts of interest are declared where relevant
- ☐ the committee applies the methodology consistently and objectively

GOOD GOVERNANCE SIGNS

- ✓ the committee works to a clear mandate
- ✓ decisions are not overly dependent on one person
- ✓ members are trained and calibrated
- ✓ confidentiality is respected
- ✓ there is continuity from one session to the next

4 Quality of Evaluation Inputs

Governance is weakened when poor information drives decisions. Check whether:

- ☐ enough role information is available before evaluation begins
- ☐ reporting lines and organisational context are clear
- ☐ the process uses role evidence rather than opinion alone
- ☐ the organisation understands that job descriptions may be useful but are not always sufficient
- ☐ knowledgeable people are available to support clarification where needed

GOOD GOVERNANCE SIGNS

- ✓ the process is evidence-based

- ✓ the role is evaluated, not the person
- ✓ evaluators have enough context to apply judgment consistently

5 Documentation and Audit Trail

Strong governance depends on having a reliable record of what was decided and why. Check whether:

- ☐ evaluation decisions are documented
- ☐ factor judgments or rationale are captured at an appropriate level
- ☐ final grade outcomes are recorded centrally
- ☐ records are retained in a way that supports future review
- ☐ changes to roles, grades, or recommendations can be tracked over time
- ☐ there is a clear audit trail for formal approvals and deviations where applicable

GOOD GOVERNANCE SIGNS

- ✓ the organisation can explain how a decision was reached
- ✓ historical decisions can be reviewed if challenged
- ✓ governance does not depend on memory or informal discussion alone

6 Appeals Management

Appeals are an important part of governance when they are structured properly. Check whether:

- ☐ employees and managers understand whether appeals are allowed
- ☐ the grounds for appeal are clear
- ☐ timeframes for appeal are defined
- ☐ there is a designated route for receiving and reviewing appeals
- ☐ appeals are handled objectively and consistently
- ☐ the outcome of appeals is documented and communicated appropriately

GOOD GOVERNANCE SIGNS

- ✓ appeals are based on process or role evidence, not preference
- ✓ the organisation can distinguish between valid and invalid appeals
- ✓ there is a consistent method for closing out appeal matters

7 Regrading Discipline

A common governance weakness is regrading roles too easily or for the wrong reasons. Check whether the organisation is clear on:

- ☐ what justifies a regrading request
- ☐ what level of role change is considered material
- ☐ what evidence is required before regrading is considered

- ☐ what factors should not trigger regrading
- ☐ how frequently re-evaluation may take place unless there is a material exception

GOOD GOVERNANCE SIGNS

- ✓ regrading is disciplined, not reactive
- ✓ role changes are assessed on evidence
- ✓ pay pressure, tenure, or retention concerns do not automatically become grading requests

8 Role and Process Ownership

A governance process is only sustainable if the organisation knows who owns it. Check whether:

- ☐ HR is clearly identified as process custodian
- ☐ line managers understand their responsibilities for role information and documentation
- ☐ committee accountability is understood
- ☐ executive oversight is clear where required
- ☐ the organisation knows who maintains the job library, records, and policy documents over time

GOOD GOVERNANCE SIGNS

- ✓ ongoing ownership does not disappear once the initial project is complete
- ✓ the process remains active and maintained
- ✓ there is a clear internal home for the methodology

9 Sustainability Check

Governance should support long-term use, not only a one-time project. Ask:

- ☐ can the organisation apply the process consistently in future?
- ☐ can new roles be graded within the same governance rules?
- ☐ can regrading be managed without confusion or escalation drift?
- ☐ does the organisation have enough internal understanding to maintain the process?
- ☐ is the process credible beyond HR alone?

If the answer to several of these is no, the governance model may need strengthening.

FINAL READINESS QUESTIONS

Before relying on the current process, ask:

- Do we have clear request and approval rights?
- Do we have a usable policy?
- Do we have a disciplined committee structure?
- Do we have reliable documentation and audit trail?
- Do we have a fair and consistent appeals process?
- Do we have enough internal ownership to sustain the process?

If not, the organisation may have a methodology, but not yet a well-governed job evaluation system.

FINAL NOTE

Good governance does not make job evaluation bureaucratic. Done well, it creates clarity, consistency, defensibility, trust in outcomes, and confidence that the process can be sustained over time. That is what allows job evaluation to support broader decisions around structure, fairness, and reward with greater credibility.

Strengthen the governance around your grading

Book a working session to see how Engage supports fair, transparent, and well-governed job evaluation.

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Engage Job Evaluation is a methodology of Africa People Advisory Group (APAG). · engage.africapeopleadvisory.com